

SEX, RELATIONSHIPS, AND COMMUNICATION

RELATIONAL TRANSGRESSIONS



4 TYPES OF INFIDELITY

- **1. Sexual infidelity**

- occurs when someone engages in sexual activity outside of her/his committed relationship
 - 20% to 40% of dating/cohabitating relationships are marked by sexual infidelity.
 - Self-reported data

4 TYPES OF INFIDELITY

- How common is sexual infidelity among married couples?
 - GSS 2019 survey:
 - Have you had sex with someone other than your spouse while married?
 - 17.5% of married individuals said “yes.”
 - The most recent data suggest that rates of sexual infidelity among heterosexual men and heterosexual women is very similar.

4 TYPES OF INFIDELITY

- **2. Emotional infidelity**

- occurs when someone is emotionally attached to or “in love with” a potential rival
 - May or may not have a sexual component

4 TYPES OF INFIDELITY

- **3. Communicative infidelity**

- occurs when people engage in sexual activity with a third party to *communicate a message* to their partner.
 - Signal need for attention, means of revenge, message of dissatisfaction

4 TYPES OF INFIDELITY

- **4. Online infidelity**

- Romantic or sexual communication facilitated by internet use.
 - Some people do not consider online infidelity to be “real” infidelity.

INFIDELITY

- Why are relational variables that might predict infidelity?
 - Low level of satisfaction in relationship
 - Low level of commitment to relationship
 - Low investment / high alternatives (Investment Model)
 - Relational boredom and stagnation (self-expansion theory)
 - High level of conflict and unmet needs

INFIDELITY

- Why are relational variables that might predict infidelity?
 - Some people engage in infidelity even in satisfying relationships - suggesting motivations beyond relationship problems.
 - Self-exploration and identity
 - Novelty and sensation-seeking
 - Opportunity and circumstances
 - Validation and ego

INFIDELITY

- What are personality-level variables that might predict infidelity?
 - Feelings of neglect / loneliness
 - Desire for sexual variety
 - High levels of narcissism
 - Low levels of conscientiousness
 - Insecure attachment

INFIDELITY

- People may use infidelity to:
 - communicate dissatisfaction
 - regain control/power
 - create feelings of jealousy
 - gain revenge

DISCOVERING SEXUAL INFIDELITY

- 1. Finding out from a third party or witnessing the infidelity firsthand
 - most relationship damage
 - likely very hurtful
 - Unexpected
 - Can't really respond
 - Perception of intentionality

DISCOVERING SEXUAL INFIDELITY

- 2. Having the partner tell you on her or his own
 - least relationship damage
 - suggests partner feels badly/ guilty
 - We tend to be more forgiving if we perceive that the person who committed a transgression feels badly or guilty about what they have done.

DISCOVERING SEXUAL INFIDELITY

- 3. Having the partner admit to infidelity after you question her or him
 - falls in the middle in terms of relational damage

IMPACT OF INFIDELITY

- Partners experience a range of emotions:
 - anger, sadness, humiliation, jealousy, anxiety, shame.
- Infidelity triggers grief responses similar to trauma.
- Betrayed partners often experience post-traumatic stress symptoms (hypervigilance, intrusive thoughts)

THINKING ABOUT INFIDELITY

- Given that infidelity is a relatively common experience in relationships:
 - 1. How do people deal with it?
 - 2. Are there any potential positive consequences of infidelity?
 - 3. What does infidelity tell us about our relationships?
 - <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=P2AUat93a8Q>

THINKING ABOUT INFIDELITY



JEALOUSY

- Jealousy is the result of a relational transgression, such as a partner having a sexual or emotional affair
- Jealousy can also be seen as a transgression in its own right, when a partner's suspicions are unfounded.
 - What we will be discussing

DEFINING JEALOUSY

- Romantic jealousy
 - occurs when an individual worries that a rival could interfere with the existence or quality of her/his relationship.
 - “Steal” the partner away.
 - Feeling insecure or fearful about the character of the relationship
 - Also feeling insecure about ourselves -- “I’m not going to be okay without my partner.”

JEALOUS THOUGHTS

Primary Appraisals:

- General evaluations about the existence and quality of the threat
 1. Does a rival exist?
 - Rival might be real or imagined
 2. Is the rival a threat to the relationship?
 - Threat might be real or imagined

JEALOUS THOUGHTS

Secondary appraisals

1. Motives for partner's interest?

- Why is my partner interested in the rival?
 - Real or imagined interest

2. Comparisons to the rival

- Am I better than the rival?
 - Along dimensions of perceived importance

JEALOUS THOUGHTS

3. Evaluation of alternatives

- What would I do without my partner? Be single? Date someone else?

4. Assessment of potential loss

- How devastated would I be without my partner?

JEALOUS THOUGHTS

Why do people make primary and secondary appraisals?

- To plan coping strategies
 - Individuals often believe that jealousy will keep them from being surprised, help them defend their rights, and learn how their partner “really” feels

JEALOUS EMOTIONS

- Fear and anger are most central
 - Fear of losing partner.
 - Anger at partner, anger at rival, anger at self for not being able to “keep” partner.

COMMUNICATIVE RESPONSES TO JEALOUSY

1. Constructive Responses:

Integrative communication

Calm, direct, non-aggressive way of disclosing feelings and asking for an explanation

COMMUNICATIVE RESPONSES TO JEALOUSY

Constructive responses

- Compensatory restoration
 - Doing something to improve self
 - New interests, hobbies, appearance
 - Doing something to improve the relationship
 - Pro-social maintenance behaviors
 - Active listening

COMMUNICATIVE RESPONSES TO JEALOUSY

- 2. Destructive responses:
 - Negative communication
 - Arguing, cold looks, sarcasm
 - Violent communication
 - Violent threats or actual violence
 - Counterjealousy inductions
 - Trying to make *partner* jealous
 - Communicative infidelity

COMMUNICATIVE RESPONSES TO JEALOUSY

- 3. Avoidant Responses:
 - Denial of jealous feelings
 - Silence about jealous feelings

COMMUNICATIVE RESPONSES TO JEALOUSY

- 4. Rival-Focused Responses:
 - Signs of possession
 - Verbally and non-verbally Communicating to others that the partner is “taken”
 - Derogating competitors
 - Making fun of the rival
 - Rival contacts
 - Communicating with rival

OBSESSIVE RELATIONAL INTRUSION (ORI)

- ORI defined:
 - Repeated and unwanted pursuit and invasion of one's sense of physical or symbolic privacy by another person, either stranger or acquaintance, who desires and/or presumes an intimate relationship.

OBSESSIVE RELATIONAL INTRUSION (ORI)

- Common ORI situations involve unrequited love between:
 - Acquaintances
 - Former relational partners
 - One person wants the relationship to continue.
 - One person wanting a platonic friendship to turn romantic

OBSESSIVE RELATIONAL INTRUSION (ORI)

- Examples of ORI behaviors:

Common Forms

- repeated calls and/or texts
- repeated social media posts
- repeatedly asking for another chance
- watching from a distance
- making exaggerated claims of affection

OBSESSIVE RELATIONAL INTRUSION (ORI)

Severe Forms (commonly known as stalking):

- invading one's home
- damaging property
- causing physical harm

COMPONENTS OF ORI

- 1. Lack of mutual agreement regarding the nature or even the existence of a relationship.

COMPONENTS OF ORI

- 2. ORI is not associated with a singular event, but is repeated.
 - Pursuit is persistent despite the absence of reciprocity by the other person and despite resistance by the other person.
 - The episodes of unwanted behavior tend to escalate over time, with the seriousness rising and the time between incidents shortening.

COMPONENTS OF ORI

- 3. Intrusion can be symbolic and psychological, not just physical.

REASONS FOR ORI

- 1. Relational scripts, particularly those regarding the establishment of romantic/sexual relationships, often idealize and reward persistence.

REASONS FOR ORI



REASONS FOR ORI

- 2. Indirect or ambiguous communication
 - It can be very difficult to tell another person you are not interested in them when they are clearly interested in you.
 - In most instances, we don't want to hurt another person's feelings, so we use indirect or ambiguous communication.
 - Which may be misinterpreted
 - "This person is just playing hard to get."
 - Another cultural script that may encourage ORI

REASONS FOR ORI

- Unrequited love can cause an individual to fixate on a desired person and “justify” (in their own minds) the use of unhealthy pursuit strategies.

ORI

- Flirting behaviors can turn into ORI behaviors if:
 - The flirtee repeatedly indicates he/she is not interested.
 - The flirtee repeatedly does not reciprocate the flirting behaviors.
 - The flirter feels like he/she is having to work very hard to get the other person's attention.

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- Theory that explains why ORI behaviors occur.
 - Three parts.

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- 1. People expend energy to develop or re-initiate relationships to the extent that they perceive a relationship is desirable and attainable.

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- 2. When a relationship is perceived to be unattainable, people abandon their original goal and seek an alternative.

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- 3. ORI behaviors are most likely when people continue to believe a relationship is attainable even though it is not.

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- People who use ORIs in an attempt to get closer to another person:
 - Mentally link the desired relationship to exaggerated feelings of happiness and exaggerated feeling of self-worth.
 - “I will never be happy unless he/she goes out with me.”
 - “I know I am a good person if he/she goes out with me.”

RELATIONAL GOAL PURSUIT THEORY

- These mental links also produces exaggerated negative feelings toward failing to “win” the other person over.
 - “I am worthless unless he/she goes out with me.”
- These mental links tend to discourage people from stopping their ORI behaviors and tend to mentally reinforce the importance of a relationship with the other person.